

“To have dissolved 554 States by integrating them into the pattern of the Republic; to have brought about order out of the nightmare of chaos whence we started…should steel us on to the attainment of equal success in other spheres. For the first time, India has become an integrated whole in the real sense of the term…”

VP Menon, 1956

India in 2022 consists of twenty-eight states and eight union territories, but this wasn’t always the case. In fact, the subcontinent on the eve of Independence was divided into British India (the territory directly under British control), and over five hundred large, medium-sized and tiny princely states (Hyderabad, Jammu and Kashmir, and Mysore, for example, were all princely states). Their rulers had signed treaties with the British that gave the latter a degree of control over their kingdoms in exchange for riches or protection. And then there were parts of India that were